



1 For the smart-casual or semi-formal look, the loafer is a must

2 The name brogue is derived from the Gaelic word 'bróg' which means shoe

3 Chukka boots bridge the gap between casual and formal

4 A classic Oxford will get you through more moments in your life than any other men's shoe

lieu of laces, these are the best option when a loafer won't do and a lace-up seems too choosy. Monk straps are perfect for casual Friday dressing or dinner with friends on weekends. You can even wear them with denims.

Brogues and Chukka boots are also iconic styles. Blending elegance with a dash of ruggedness makes these shoes versatile. Brogues have their roots in the fields of Scotland and Ireland, where they were initially designed as sturdy work shoes for the working class. The name brogue is derived from the Gaelic word 'bróg' which means shoe. The early brogues were made of untanned hide and had perforations in the leather to help drain out the water as farmers and labourers waded through the terrain. Over time they underwent a transformation and in the 19th century became popular among British aristocracy. Perforations which once had a practical purpose became a design statement and today they give brogues their distinct look.

Chukka boots—ankle-high boots with two-three eyelets and a simple unadorned design—trace their origin to the deserts of North Africa. British soldiers stationed in Egypt during World War II were introduced to these boots, often worn by the lo-

cal populace. They started referring to them as 'Chukkas' in reference to a period of play in polo. They became extremely popular post the War as they bridge the gap between casual and formal, making them extremely versatile.

And of course, no wardrobe is complete without a pair of sneakers, irrespective of whether you lead a physically active lifestyle. While the history of sneakers is rooted in practicality and athletic performance, they are more of a go-to shoe today than anything else. It was in the late 19th century that vulcanised rubber soles were developed, leading to the first rubber-soled athletic shoes. However, the term 'sneakers' only became popular in the 20th century as wearers could move quietly and 'sneak' around. Today they are a global fashion phenomenon with some being sold for several thousand dollars. Luxury sneakers such as those by Gucci, Prada, and Louis Vuitton are blurring the line between casual and formal, making them shoes to live in.

Dressing up from the bottom to the top can make all the difference. So go ahead, put your best foot forward. **BT**

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